

ENG101

Lesson – 44

Articles and Their Use.

Major / Content words – Noun, Verb,
Adjective, Adverb
Minor / Function words – Determiners,
Pronouns,
Prepositions,
Conjunctions

Determiners come before nouns & adjectives

- The cat sat on my bag. (art, poss)
- I don't want any tea. (indef deter)
- Have you some yogurt? (indef deter)

There are 5 main types of determiners.

(i) articles: a, an, the

(ii) demonstratives: this, that, these, those

(iii) possessives: my, you, his, her, its, our, them

(iv) quantifiers: some, any, all, enough, no, both, each, ever, few, much,
more, most, fewer, less, either, neither

(v) wh-determiners: what (ever) which(ever) whoever, whose

This party will be the /di/ social event of the week.

2. Article Usage: The general rules are:

(a). The definite article 'the' can be used with all kinds of nouns except most proper nouns.

sing. count nouns the dog / child / train

plural count nouns the dogs / children /

trains

Sing. mass nouns the silver / water

(b) The indefinite article 'a/ an' can normally only be used with singular count nouns:

e.g. a ball / child / exams

plural count nouns: (some) balls/children/

examssingular mass nouns: (some) silver/milk/

knowledgeFor other nouns the zero article i.e. no article at all is used for indefinite meaning. Look at the following table which summarizes the above rules.

	Definite mg	Indefinite meaning
sing. count noun	the train	a train
pl. count noun	the trains	(some) trains
mass noun	the silver	(some) silver

with sing. count nouns or plural count nouns. e.g. - *Would you like a soda?*

- *Do you like chocolate?*

(zero indef. article with mass noun 'chocolate')

1 sing. count nouns: nouns showing 'one':

a girl, the chair,

2 plural count nouns: nouns showing 'more than one': two girls, five chairs

3 mass nouns : advertising, music, butter, evidence, etc)

There are 4 conditions in which definite meaning arise. We use the definite article for: (1)

Referring – back use: When identity has been established by an earlier mention e.g.

- *Saba bought a TV and a video recorder, but she returned the video recorder* (second mention). (2) Forward-Pointing Use: When identity is established by the post modification

that follows the noun: e.g.

Saba returned the view-recorder she bought yesterday.

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The definite article 'the' has a Generic or Typical use when it refers to what is general or typical for a whole class of things. This use of 'the' is found with count nouns. e.g.

i) *'The' peacock is a beautiful bird.*

Here 'the' indicates the class of birds, not one individual member of the class.

ii) *-Peacocks are beautiful birds.*

(general use of the plural indefinite form)

iii) *- A peacock is a beautiful bird.*

(generic use of the indefinite singular).

We can say *the peacock* (generic) refers to the species as a whole, while *a peacock*

(generic) refers to any member of the species. We can say:

The peacock is in danger of becoming extinct

But not:

A peacock is in danger of becoming extinct.

5. Specific vs Generic Meaning

Another way of explaining the use of the definite article is to look at it from the specific vs generic meaning. The following examples illustrate the use of the definite article with generic or typical meaning.

a) I like milk, Belgian glass, Burmese wood..

(concrete mass noun; no definite article)

b) I like music, Punjabi mystical poetry,
contemporary art...

(abstract mass noun; def. article not used)

c) I like dogs, horses, oriental languages...

definite article not used with plural nouns)

But see how the following nouns take the definite article.

Specific use

Generic use

a) Pass the butter please

Butter is imported nowadays

b) The acting was poor but
we the music was super.

I simply love acting and music

-Before you visit Japan,
you ought to learn

Linguistics is the study of
language

the language

c) Come and look at
the puppies

I simply love puppies.

Mass nouns (abstract) followed by –of phrase take the definite article

The following table will make this clear.

1. Japanese history	<u>the</u> history of Japan
2. Pakistani society	the society of Pakistan
3. Early Moghal Architecture	the architecture of early Moghal period
4. Child behavior	the behavior of children

We find that with concrete mass nouns and plural nouns 'the' can be omitted as in

-eighteenth century furniture (the) furniture of

-tropical birds
tropics

eighteenth century
(the) birds of the

6. Adjectives & Group Nouns

'The' is also used with adjectives to show

i) a class of people: - *the poor, the rich, the disabled, the wealthy, the handicapped*

OR

ii) to denote an abstract quality: *the sublime, the ridiculous, the absurd.*

'The' is also used with adjectives showing nationality especially those ending in 'ch' or 'sh' e.g.

-*the Dutch, the English, the French, the Spanish*

'The' is also used with group nouns like:

-*the aristocracy, the public, the administration, the government*

which can be used with either a singular or a plural verb e.g.

- *The audience is/are enjoying the music*

- *The police never decide/decides in a hurry.*

7. Some Common Nouns Without Article

The following is a list of groups of common nouns without article, which occur mainly in idiomatic expressions. These are given under column I. Under Column II are examples where the article is used:

I		II
A) INSTITUTIONS		
be in	{ bed church prison hospital	lie down on <u>the</u> bed
go to		walk past <u>the</u> church
		drive by <u>the</u> prison
		live by <u>the</u> hospital
be at	{ school college sea university	go into <u>the</u> school
		<u>the</u> college tower has collapsed
		look out towards <u>the</u> sea
		work at <u>the</u> University
be at home, go home	{	approach <u>the</u> town
be in town, leave town		

(B) Means of Transport

(no article)

(With article)

come	{ by bike/bicycle by bus by boat/ship by train by plane	ride on <u>the</u> bicycle
leave		catch <u>the</u> bus
travel		get on <u>the</u> boat
		get into <u>the</u> train
		get off <u>the</u> plane

(C) Times of the Day

		at dawn, at daybreak during <u>the</u> day
meet	{ at sunrise, at sunset at noon, at midnight at dusk, at twilight at night, by night night	admire <u>the</u> sunrise/sunset
leave		in <u>the</u> afternoon
		invisible in <u>the</u> dusk
		wake up in <u>the</u> middle of the

(D) Meals (no article)

have breakfast/lunch/tea
dinner/supper

Dinner is at eight

(with article)

Were you at the lunch
for the stars?

Have you made the tea?

The dinner was well cooked

(E) Parallel Phrases**(no article)**

They walked arm in arm

They walked hand in hand

They are husband and wife

(with article)

She took him by the arm

A bird in the hand is worth
two in the bush

She's the wife of a famous
pop star.

8. ARTICLES AND PROPER NOUNS

Proper nouns usually take no articles.

A. Personal Name: James Brown, Hilary Shaw, but

- the President of the United States of America - the Lord (God)

- the Duke of Edinburgh

Family Terms:

No article is used in the vocative

- hello mummy, hello daddy,

- did you thank aunty/uncle?

B. Calendar Items

a) Names of Festivals: Christmas, Eid, Independence Day, Republic Day

b) Names of the months & the days of week:

January, February, Monday, Tuesday

c) Names of seasons may have the article omitted:

... I met them in summer BUT

.... in the summer of 1945

Geographical Names

Normally there is no article whether the name is pre-modified

a) Names of continents

(Central) Asia, (East) Africa

b) Names of Countries

ancient Bhutan

modern Pakistan

(Victorian) England

(medieval) India

Exceptions: The Sahara, the Punjab,

the Lebanon, the Middle East,

the Ukraine, the Crimea.

c) Cities & Towns: Rome, Lahore, Karachi, Sibi

Exceptions: The Hague, The West End

d) Lakes & Mountains: Mount Everest Mount K-2

Article with Proper Nouns

e) Plural Names:

-The Himalayas, the Alps, The Rockies

-The Austins (meaning 'the Austin family')

-The Netherlands, the Midlands

-The Indus, the Ravi, the Atlantic, the Pacific

-The Suez Canal, the Panama Canal

f) Public Places

- hotels & restaurants - the Moghal, the Hilton
- cinemas, clubs - the globe, the gymkhana
- museum, - the Lahore Museum,
- the British Museum

g) Magazines & periodicals normally have no article: Newsweek, Time, Punch, Mag, New Scientist.

Practice 1:

Insert an article where you think it is needed

1. We went to most expensive restaurant in town.
2. Do you want to watch television this evening?
3. Last night we went out for meal in restaurant.
4. Braille is a system of reading and writing by touch for blind.

Practice 2:

Choose the correct form, with or without 'the'

1. I am afraid of dogs / the dogs
2. Can you pass salt / the salt, please?
3. Women / the women are sometimes better teachers than men / the men
4. Second World War / The Second World War ended in 1945.
5. All books / All the books on the top shelf belong to me
6. Tom left college / the college without taking his exams.
7. After the work / work Ann usually goes to the home / home.

Practice 3:

Some of the following sentences are correct, but some need the definite article. Can you spot those that need correction?

1. Next year we are going skiing in Swiss Alps. ____
2. Nile is longest river in Africa. ____
3. There are many different languages spoken in Far East. ____
4. They now live in the United Arab Emirates / United Arab Emirates. ____
5. South of England is warmer than north. ____
6. United Kingdom consists of Great Britain and Northern Ireland. ____
7. Plains of Punjab are very hot in May and June. ____
8. Malta has been a republic since 1974. ____

Practice 4:

Choose the correct form with or without 'the'. 1. One of the oldest buildings in Lahore is Old Fort / the Old Fort.

2. "Which hotel are you staying at?"
"At Sheraton / the Sheraton."
3. Yesterday I opened an account at Standard Chartered Bank / the Standard Chartered Bank.
4. Have you ever visited the University of Management Sciences / University of Management Sciences?
5. 'Where did you buy those shoes?'
'At Service's / the Services'.
6. The President / President of United States / the United States lives in White House / the White House.
7. "Is there a cinema hall near here?"

“Yes, Odeon / the Odeon on Montgomery Road /
the Montgomery Road.”